

Family Business

by Saritha Rao Rayachoti

AT THE DINDUKKAL BUS DEPOT, the abortionist pushed her way through the crowd thronging the bus and finally managed to board it. She placed her travel bag beside her on the seat, calling out to her niece to hurry up. The young woman renewed her efforts to break free of the tangle of limbs and claim the seat reserved for her.

The call on the abortionist's new cell had come today at a most inappropriate time—right in the middle of her granddaughter's puberty function. To hear that particular ringtone go off during such an auspicious event was nothing short of embarrassing.

But she had to admit that the contraption itself was useful. It made her more accessible and brought in business she would have otherwise missed while away on assignments. She was still grappling with all the cell's functions, but at least she knew how to answer calls and how to keep the phone charged. All that remained was to learn to use the radio. And learn to change the ringtone. Her grandson would have a lot to answer for when she returned home from work that evening.

She hoped that, just like the cell, the arrival of an apprentice would also usher in more business. Just yesterday, her niece from the city had expressed a keenness to earn a living in the business of taking lives. The abortionist had been surprised that, in this day and age, somebody actually wanted to learn this skill. It was also news to her that there was demand for people like her in the city. It would be a

whole new market. She could send supplies to her niece every week with the help of her neighbour who drove a lorry.

But she was not sure the girl was up to the task. As someone who had grown up in the city, she would not have the stomach for getting the job done by any means necessary. The abortionist believed that in her line of work one could not afford to have qualms. Her mother had been an abortionist and, when the situation had demanded it, she had taken over.

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She pulled out a newspaper-wrapped packet and extracted two jaam-bun that she had bought earlier at the bakery near the bus stand. She gave one to the girl and then savoured her own, sinking her teeth into soft-baked dough, the indulgence leaving a smear of blood-red jam on her lips.

"Athai," asked the niece tentatively, "You were an abortionist, then a midwife. When did you start killing infants?"

This was as good a time as any other to begin the girl's tutelage. The abortionist smacked her lips and began.

Karpagam dreamed that she was Devagi.

She gave birth to a new child every day and her evil brother, King Kamsan, killed it. On the one hand, he loved her dearly; on the other, he felt threatened by the prophecy that her eighth offspring would kill him. Kamsan took no chances. He even counted the miscarriages and the stillborns. Devagi wanted this cycle of death to stop, but the only way it would



Illustration: Shamanthi Rajasingham

was if she ended it herself.

Devagi's husband, Vasudevan, was a kind man, but unable to contain his lust for her. He was ever ready to bear the brunt of her anger and sorrow at losing so many of their children. Perhaps the guilt of his lust emasculated him, but only until the dead of the night, when she felt his hand reach for her, setting in motion a new cycle of life and death.

Today's birthing was more difficult than the others. Devagi went through many hours of painful labour. The prison midwife was not to be found. Neither were the guards. She finally ejected a mass that felt like stone. It was not a baby, it was an idol of goddess Durgai Amman.

Vasudevan helped cut the umbilical cord with the serrated edge of a broken earthen lamp. He wiped the idol with water from the drinking pot and brought the newborn to her. She looked into the cold all-seeing eyes of Durgai Amman and wondered how she was going to save this child.

Suddenly, the gates unlocked. Devagi was sure that it was all the doing of her little Durgai Amman. Vasudevan seized the opportunity. There was a baby boom in the kingdom, and there was bound to be some newborn that could swap destinies with this one. After all, goddesses needed to be protected.

He was gone a long time and Devagi began to panic. What if the midwife arrived? What about the guards? What if Kamsan returned before Vasudevan was back?

When at last Vasudevan returned, the gates locked shut behind him. He had with him a baby swaddled in the same spare saree that she had wrapped her Durgai Amman in.

Vasudevan handed the baby to her and said, "Kamsan can do as he pleases with this

one." There was an edge to his voice that unnerved Devagi.

When she looked into the eyes of the baby, Devagi felt a deep sense of peace wash over her. This was no ordinary infant. She felt an overwhelming sense of being a mere enabler to some cosmic drama that would unfold through this baby. She knew in that instant, beyond any measure of doubt, that this child would live.

“Twenty years ago, I did only abortions. Then, scans were introduced in aaspathris and villagers began to flock to them. Once they came to know that a foetus was female, they could get the abortion done then and there. The doctors claimed that they would do a more hygienic job, so I lost a lot of business. Mind you, I have a reputation for hygienic procedures too—not a single complication in all the years I have been aborting foetuses.”

“And then?”

“Business was lean,” said the abortionist. She opened a drawstring pouch, pulled out a betel leaf and proceeded to smear it with lime paste. “What could I do? A slump happens in every business. I was a midwife for a while, but I was just biding my time until something better came up.”

The abortionist placed a couple of shavings of betel nut on the leaf.

“What happened when the government imposed that ban on sex determination tests?”

"Parents, especially the poorer ones, never had the option anyway. But the rich too now had to wait until the child was born to determine its fate. Thankfully, there has always existed a parallel business of despatching unwanted female infants in our villages. Kill-

ing a foetus and killing an infant are not the same thing. The infant-killer of the village taught me all that she knew before she died.” The abortionist placed the filled and folded betel leaf into her mouth. She chewed for a few seconds, unable to speak through a full, pursed mouth.

“Was the first one difficult?” asked the niece tentatively.

The abortionist stopped chewing, the astringent betel juice in her mouth now tasting bitter. She looked out of the window of the bus as vast fields passed in a haze. The niece waited, fidgeting with the bus tickets in her hand, folding them over and over again.

Turning to her niece, the abortionist used an endearment to soften the message. “Kannu,” she said. “You will have to steel yourself. This business is not for the faint-hearted. But I promise that in time, you will get used to it and will be adept at doing the deed in your sleep.”

The abortionist noticed that her niece looked unsure. Maybe the girl was better off scouring vessels for a living.

The niece finally said, “I cannot afford to be sensitive anymore.

I have to learn to be tough. Tell me about the techniques.”

The abortionist noted the hint of determination, but hesitated, “Are you sure?”

The niece nodded.

“The oldest techniques were very effective. One method was to place the baby on the floor and bring one leg of a cot down on its head.”

Her niece winced.

“But this is the least favoured method,” said the abortionist quickly, “It is messy. Another option is to use a handful of rice husks soaked in milk. But a choking infant is also a disturbing sight. These days, one just needs to swaddle the infant with...look!”

Suddenly, the abortionist pointed to a row of plants flanking the road. The plants had thick leaves and fleshy purple-tinged flowers.

“Have you seen these before in the city? This is the most effective poison, Erukku. We worship Vinayakan with it, but it is also a fine medicinal drug, as good to induce abortions as it is to kill an infant. At the house we are going to today, they have already arranged for it.”

The abortionist was all set to spit the betel juice out of the window, when she noticed the bus conductor sitting right behind her. He would give her an earful if even a drop spilt on the side of the bus.

Today's birthing was more difficult than the others. Devagi went through many hours of painful labour. The prison midwife was not to be found. Neither were the guards. She finally ejected a mass that felt like stone. It was not a baby, it was an idol of Durgai Amman

The dream made absolutely no sense. There was no Kamsan. And she was not Krishna's mother, Devagi, leave alone that part about giving birth to a child every day! She was Karpagam, the younger daughter-in-law of the wealthiest family in the district. The only part that was real, was about a husband, and about her having just delivered a child.

She looked around and found the space next to her empty. She was in the sick room, reserved for the infirm, the dying and women in labour. This room had seen many deaths,

its only window opening on to the adjoining street. Her father-in-law had wasted away on this cot as, one by one, his organs failed. This was the cot on which her niece had lain with chicken pox and had taken an inordinately long time to recover. This was where her sisters-in-law had given birth.

Only her mother-in-law and the midwife were present at each delivery in the family. The infant-killer always waited outside, just in case. The killings were usually completed before the mother regained consciousness, with no evidence of a recent birth, save the abrupt hollowness inside her. People would be told that the baby was born dead, although it was common knowledge what happened to babies of the wrong sex. A mike-set and amplifier would be arranged, and professional mourners would beat their chests and sing dirges for the departed soul, their wails reaching the mother as she lay in the dark innards of the house.

An angry wail rent the air.

Karpagam raised herself on her elbow.

“Amma!” she called out urgently.

It was alive! Her baby was alive! Her mother-in-law was probably outside, finally celebrating the birth of the one who would carry on their lineage.

The midwife appeared at the door. The wails grew louder, until Karpagam could bear it no longer. “This one...?”

“No.”

Karpagam bristled, “Then why is it still

here? Why have they not killed this one like the rest?”

“The woman is late. She is on her way from Dindukkal.” The midwife held out a silver cup with milk.

“Take it away.”

“You are weak in body, and this will help you heal faster.”

Suddenly, Karpagam rose to a sitting position, adjusted her saree and tied her dishevelled hair into a knot. “Let that bitch come one step closer to my child! I will tear her limbs from her body.”

The midwife tried to restrain her, “Not in the state you are in. You need to think of your own health.”

Pain ripped through her body and Karpagam plunged into a dark chasm.

The distinct rhythm of the Saa-vu Mozham evokes a primal echo in the blood of the listener, a reminder of sorts about one’s own mortality. A tinny rendition resonated in the bus now, evoking tongue-clicks from disapproving passengers shocked at the frivolity of using it as a ringtone. The abortionist quickly answered the call.

“Yes, yes. I am on my way. I am

sorry it got delayed, Amma,” she said in the obsequious tone she reserved for her clients.

“I will be there in...” She turned to the bus conductor, “Hey, you, how long until we reach?”

“Why? Is the President of India waiting there to award you a medal, or what?”

The abortionist seized the opportunity to

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spit a vibrant streak of red betel juice on the dirty floor of the bus. Now clear of all impediments to free speech, she yelled at the bus conductor, “Porukki, sollu! You scoundrel, answer me! How long?”

“About fifteen minutes,” he said, then muttered his own share of expletives under his breath.

The abortionist returned to her call, “Amma, fifteen minutes. The big house near the Panchayat Office or the other?... Are they there already? Give them some kaapi to prepare their voices and I will be there before they finish drinking...” She listened some more, and replied, “You are very kind. Just let me know when she is due. It is our good fortune that you provide us our daily kanji, Amma. Thank you.”

When she hung up, her niece asked, sneaking a sidelong glance at the bus conductor, “Athai, people call you a murderess. Don’t you get angry?”

The abortionist said, “First, be a good girl and change this ringtone. My grandson, that rascal, must have thought he was being very smart when he set it.”

The girl smiled, and taking the instrument, worked deftly. The new ringtone sounded, to the abortionist’s ears, like the clanging of aluminium vessels. Better the vessels than the death drum.

“You are such a smart girl,” said the abortionist. “You should be working in an aapees.”

“If I could, why would I be here?” sighed the niece, “You know that I was married early. He disliked the idea of my working outside home. Now, after his death, if I have to continue living in the city, I need a job that pays me enough to support myself. With my eighth standard pass, do you think someone will give me work in an office?”

The abortionist said, “Listen carefully, kannu. In our line of work, we will be called many names—pishachi, rakshasi. We need to tune it all out. No matter what they call me, I prefer to call myself a maruthuvachi. There is some respect and honour in being called a midwife, even though I am so much more than a midwife or a medicine woman. With all their wealth, if they wanted to...”

“Wealth?” the niece sat up, “When you were talking on the cell, you said something about a big house? Do rich people also...”

“Of course! I only work with the rich land-owners of the district. There are eight such families and each family, at this point, has about three or four fertile women as daughters-in-law.”

“Why do you work only with them?”

“Because I charge a premium for secrecy that they can afford to pay me. They also ensure the police is taken care of. If there is an enquiry, I can get as much into trouble as the families.”

“But the rich—surely they can afford to bring up these children?”

The abortionist sighed, “From what I have seen, kannu, the more money people have, the more particular they are about a suitable heir for all that wealth.”

The niece fell silent.

“Listen,” said the abortionist, dropping her voice, “Do you know what’s different about today’s assignment?”

The niece shook her head.

“It is a male child.”

“What?”

“The one we will be...working with today.”

A hand rose up to the niece’s mouth, even as a gasp escaped her.

“I thought...aren’t they...?”

The abortionist whispered, “Coveted? That was until the sperm banks came up.”

“Is that a recent development?”

“A couple of years ago, the government set up these banks along with some faarin company. They had a cash incentive scheme that had the men scurrying there so it could fund their preferred vice, which was usually drinking at the state-run toddy shop.”

“Athai, I still don’t understand. Not all men would have gone, no? How did that lead to such a big change?”

“Kannu, there is now too much sperm in the sperm banks. Supply outstrips demand by so much that there’s even a premium charged for a family scheme for those who believe in pure blood and lineage. Which basically makes men redundant, besides some maintenance income and, of course, recreation.”

The niece blushed. “What about the women?”

“Until a few years ago, the female child was the liability. Today, the winds have changed. She is beginning to be celebrated as the carrier of lineage. Wombs are now sacred, and goddesses need to be protected. I expect that in a few years, entire villages will turn matriarchal.”

“So nothing has changed for the women? They continue bearing children. Until a few years ago, girls were the unwanted sex, but the matriarchs have now decided it is the boys?” Said the niece, “If women are taking these decisions, they could have put an end to infant-killing entirely?”

“You are very smart, kannu. One would think that if women had the power that they were denied over all these centuries, they would turn the world into a more bearable place. But the nature of power is beastly. It goes

to one’s head and begins its deathly dance. It is difficult to explain to matriarchs that although male babies are a drain on the household finances, you still need them for basic labour, and to perform a role in funeral rites and other religious ceremonies.”

“Athai, do you think a day might dawn when no child will be killed?”

The abortionist pondered the question.

“When that day comes, what will we do, Athai?” asked the niece who, in that moment became the abortionist’s apprentice.

“If the goddess has given us a skill, she will also provide us the means to make a livelihood from it. For the time being, we will go with the flow. If things balance out, and if there are no babies to be killed, we will be out of this business. We can then go back to performing abortions. Or deliveries.”

Karpagam felt nuzzling and looked down at the baby taking short breaths against her bosom. He had a lot of hair on his head. She touched his ear lightly and he yawned.

“He stopped crying when we placed him next to you,” said the midwife. “We had to keep him quiet until the infant-killer got here.”

The midwife again extended a glass of milk to her.

Karpagam tensed.

The midwife shrugged, “Not for him, not that milk. This is for you. Now drink this up so I can leave. I have no more business here.”

Karpagam propped herself up on her elbow and sipped the milk.

This child would live, she would ensure that. And she would call him Kannan after Lord Krishna, the eighth child of Devagi. The one that got away.

Karpagam felt a cocoon of calm descend

over her. Now that her decision was made, there was no conflict, no anger, no pain. She would simply tell them firmly that she was keeping Kannan. She knew that her husband would approve of her decision. Not that his approval mattered anymore, but some old ways of thinking rose unbidden to the surface even today.

The abortionist and her apprentice gathered their belongings and stepped off the bus. They had to walk down the main street and turn left, and the big house would be right there.

The older woman wondered if the girl would stay and learn the business. What if she was too squeamish? It would be good to have someone answer calls on the cell and keep track of appointments, someone to carry on the family business, someone to share the everyday burden of being called an agent of death.

As they turned the corner, they saw the massive fortress-like walls of a bungalow with a large gate. The two-storeyed house sat a little to one side of the property and there was a driveway that led from the gate to the entrance. A small

crowd had gathered to one side of the portico.

The abortionist pointed them out and said, “The mourners. You must have seen them in the city?”

“I have never heard an oppari. Not in the city, not here.”

“You do not know what you are missing, kannu. It is morbid, but strangely poetic too.”

When the apprentice started towards the entrance gate, the abortionist admonished her, “What are you doing! People like us do not enter through this gate!”

She led her to the side of the house, where a servant stood fidgeting by a small doorway. As soon as he spotted them, he turned to someone inside and said, “Amma, they are here!”

To them he hissed, “Where were you?”

A woman’s loud voice ordered him, “Let her enter, you fool! The maruthuvachi has come a long way in the hot sun. Bring her some buttermilk.” Then, as the abortionist approached, the matriarch sitting in her customary chair in the verandah, said, “Ignore him. Now come sit in the shade.”

She spotted the younger woman, and tensed, “Who is this?”

“Oh, pardon me, Amma,” said the abortionist, “This is my niece. She will assist me from now onwards. I am also getting old, no?”

“An apprentice? Is the girl any good? I hope she is not squeamish.”

The abortionist hesitated for a mere second, then said, “Of course not. I have trained her myself.”

The apprentice stepped forward and paid her respects to the matriarch, “It is our good fortune that you provide us our daily kanji, Amma. I hope you like our work enough to recommend us to your relatives in neighbouring villages.”

The matriarch turned to the abortionist and smiled, “You have taught her well.”

Delighted at the girl’s spunk, the abortion-

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ist downed the last of the buttermilk from the aluminium glass, leaving in it the curry leaves that flavoured the drink.

The matriarch pulled out a silk drawstring purse from the folds at her waist and paid the fee. "And here is a little something," she said, "as my blessing, for your granddaughter having attained puberty."

The abortionist fell at the matriarch's feet and received the money. She then beckoned to the apprentice with a brisk nod of her head and the girl followed her aunt's example.

The matriarch said, "We had a situation because of the delay. She has seen the baby. But we have handled her. You can start."

The abortionist dropped her voice to barely a whisper, and asked the matriarch cryptically, "Praise be to the blue-throated one?"

"Who are you afraid of, maruthavachi, that you speak in code?" snapped the matriarch, "You can feel free to use the word 'poison'. Don't you trust that we will protect you?"

"With you as our benefactor, we have nothing to fear, Amma," exclaimed the abortionist, bowing low again.

"You may proceed, now. We're already running late. I'm paying the oppari singers by the hour and they've been sitting idle for too long."

The abortionist stepped over the threshold and her apprentice followed.

*Aa-raa-aro Aaariraro Aaaaaaro Aariraro
The breast spouts milk, but the suckling mouth
is gone,
The sun has set, long before it is dawn
Aaaanhaaan haannnhann haannn*

Karpagam remembered the keening being louder at the previous killing in the family. Maybe the mourners were getting old. Or they

were tired. Maybe they were winding down. She may have been asleep a long, long time.

*Aa-raa-aro Aaariraro Aaaaaaro Aariraro
Swaddled in earth before he wears silk
The funeral feast before his first taste of milk
Aaaanhaaan haannnhann haannn*

Tomorrow, the ropes of the sick-cot would be ripped out and new ones would be wound around the old death-stained wooden frames, readying it for the next patient, the next victim, the next baby.

*Aa-raa-aro Aaariraro Aaaaaaro Aariraro
A dirge will be sung before his first cry
A sister will arrive to hear his lullaby
Aaaanhaaan haannnhann haannn*

Karpagam felt her husband's hand on her forehead. She brushed it away.

The abortionist led her apprentice out of the sick room, seated her on a mat in the inner courtyard and gave her a tumbler of water.

The first killing was a rite of passage, much like losing one's virginity, or losing a parent. It would feel as though time had paused, and she would watch in the clarity of that moment, a being so gloriously alive a few minutes ago, lying lifeless now because of her.

The abortionist felt a touch of pride. For someone of her naivete and city-bred ways, the girl had done rather well. Given time, she could even become a popular, sought-after professional in the business.

The sound of clanging vessels resonated in the stillness of the enclosed courtyard. The abortionist answered the call on her cell. ■